

Diamonds Productive For Salvo

Steve Salvo, assistant baseball coach at the University of Texas at El Paso, had himself quite a productive recruiting trip during the off months.

Salvo ventured to New Jersey where he signed two outstanding junior college pitchers but unfortunately lost two other prospective Miners to major league contracts.

"I think the team we have this year will be a lot different from the ones we've had in years past," said Salvo. "We recruited some pretty good pitchers and a shortstop that I think will be the best defensive shortstop in the Western Athletic Conference."

Results of Salvo's recruiting will begin to take form at noon Friday when UTEP opens the 1978 baseball season with a doubleheader against New Mexico Highlands at Tech High field.

The most interesting of Salvo's recruits

is southpaw Nick Fiorello who broke all of John Montefusco's pitching records at Brookdale Community College in New Jersey.

Montefusco, now pitching for San Francisco Giants, held several records before Fiorello spent two years compiling a 23-1 record.

Also making up UTEP's starting pitching rotation is Jim Sacco, whose 17 strikeouts in seven innings set a Cumberland Junior College record. Both are scheduled to start Friday's games. Lefty Russ Bortell out of Michigan and K. C. Nix from Ranger JC add support to what was considered a weak pitching staff last season.

Jerry Walker, a hard throwing right-hander who also does punting chores for the UTEP football team, is back for his junior year, giving Coach Andy Cohen a

relatively strong pitching staff to work with.

"Nix is an excellent spot starter and reliever," said Salvo. "You'll see a difference in our team this year."

Hard-hitting centerfielder Bob Alsup and pitcher Wes Zott are the only seniors on the team. Half of UTEP's infield returns with Art Bravo at second and Jim Bradford at third. The addition of Walker at first base when not pitching and Danny McMahon at short gives the Miners a well-rounded infield.

UTEP improved on its catching department with the return of Rick Hildebrand, a graduate from Irvin who attended Ranger for two seasons. Hildebrand was all-district while at Irvin, hitting over .400 one season.

Junior Sal Flores will be sharing time with Hildebrand as will freshman Vic Calzada from Riverside High.